

KS3: Causes of the Great War - Guided Reading Extract



The Sleepwalkers: How Europe Went to War in 1914

By Christopher Clark

"The protagonists of 1914 were sleepwalkers, watchful but unseeing, haunted by dreams, yet blind to the reality of the horror they were about to bring into the world. For decades, the narrative of the Great War's outbreak has often focused on a single villain, usually pointing the finger of blame squarely at the German Empire. However, to truly understand the catastrophe, one must look at the entire continent of Europe—a continent caught in a rigid and paranoid web of its own making. In the years leading up to 1914, Europe was dominated by a complex system of alliances. Originally designed as defensive measures to ensure peace through mutual protection, these agreements slowly morphed into dangerous tripwires. The Triple Entente, linking Britain, France, and Russia, stood in tense opposition to the Triple Alliance of Germany, Austria-Hungary, and Italy. Instead of feeling secure, the great powers felt entirely encircled and deeply suspicious of one another. The Franco-Prussian War of 1870 had left a bitter legacy; France was obsessed with regaining the lost territories of Alsace and Lorraine, while a newly unified Germany was determined to assert its dominance on the world stage. Amidst this atmosphere of mutual distrust, the military establishments across Europe grew vastly in size and influence. An unprecedented arms race took hold, most notably the fierce naval rivalry between Britain and Germany. Every nation began drafting intricate, inflexible mobilization plans. The most famous of these, the German Schlieffen Plan, dictated that in the event of war with Russia, Germany must rapidly strike and defeat France first to avoid a two-front war. Such plans meant that once the order to mobilize was given, the military timetables would take control, leaving politicians and diplomats entirely powerless to stop the descent into violence. The spark that

ignited this powder keg occurred in the volatile Balkan peninsula. The Austro-Hungarian Empire, a sprawling and multi-ethnic state, was terrified by the rise of Serbian nationalism on its southern border. When Archduke Franz Ferdinand was assassinated in Sarajevo on June 28, 1914, by a Bosnian Serb nationalist, the authorities in Vienna saw a perfect pretext to crush Serbia once and for all. They were emboldened by the infamous 'Blank Cheque' from their ally Germany, which promised unconditional support. Yet, even after the assassination, a general European war was not inevitable. The ensuing July Crisis was a masterclass in diplomatic blundering, miscalculation, and brinkmanship. Leaders sent ambiguous messages, ambassadors failed to communicate their governments' true intentions, and monarchs desperately exchanged telegrams trying to preserve the peace while simultaneously signing mobilization orders. They were all playing a high-stakes game of bluff, assuming the other side would eventually back down. When Russia chose to mobilize its massive army in defense of its Slavic ally, Serbia, the fatal clockwork mechanism of the alliance system was triggered. Germany, bound by the rigid logic of the Schlieffen Plan, declared war on Russia and immediately invaded neutral Belgium to strike at France. This violation of Belgian neutrality finally brought the British Empire into the fray. In the end, the outbreak of the First World War was not a premeditated crime planned in a single capital, but a tragic, collective failure. The statesmen of Europe were men who prided themselves on their rationality and diplomatic skill. Yet, gripped by fear, bound by rigid alliances, and overwhelmed by the speed of events, they sleepwalked past every opportunity to halt the crisis. They plunged their nations into a conflict of unprecedented scale and industrial slaughter, a war that would sweep away empires, redraw the map of the world, and cast a long, dark shadow over the rest of the twentieth century."

1. What metaphor does the author use in the opening paragraph to describe the

"The conquest of the earth, which mostly means the taking it away from those who have a different complexion or slightly flatter noses than ourselves, is not a pretty thing when you look into it too much. What redeems it is the idea only. An idea at the back of it; not a sentimental pretence but an idea; and an unselfish belief in the idea—something you can set up, and bow down before, and offer a sacrifice to... I left in a French steamer, and she called in every blamed port they have out there, for, as far as I could see, the sole purpose of landing soldiers and custom-house officers. I watched the coast. Watching a coast as it slips by the ship is like thinking about an enigma. There it is before you—smiling, frowning, inviting, grand, mean, insipid, or savage, and always mute with an air of whispering, 'Come and find out.' This one was almost featureless, as if still in the making, with an aspect of monotonous grimness. The edge of a colossal jungle, so dark-green as to be almost black, fringed with white surf, ran straight, like a ruled line, far, far away along a blue sea whose glitter was blurred by a creeping mist. The sun was fierce, the land seemed to glisten and drip with steam. Now and then a boat from the shore gave one a momentary contact with reality. It was paddled by black fellows. You could see from afar the white of their eyeballs glistening. They shouted, sang; their bodies streamed with perspiration; they had faces like grotesque masks—these chaps; but they had bone, muscle, a wild vitality, an intense energy of movement, that was as natural and true as the surf along their coast. They wanted no excuse for being there. They were a great comfort to look at. For a time I would feel I belonged still to a world of straightforward facts; but the feeling would not last long. Something would turn up to scare it away. Once, I remember, we came upon a man-of-war anchored off the coast. There wasn't even a shed there, and she was shelling the bush. It appears the French had one of their wars going on thereabouts. Her ensign dropped limp like a rag; the muzzles of the long six-inch guns stuck out all over the low hull; the greasy, slimy swell swung her up lazily and let her down, swaying her thin masts. In the empty immensity of earth, sky, and water, there she was, incomprehensible, firing into a continent. Pop, would go one of the six-inch guns; a small flame would dart and vanish, a little white smoke

would disappear, a tiny projectile would give a feeble screech—and nothing happened. Nothing could happen. There was a touch of insanity in the proceeding, a sense of lugubrious drollery in the sight; and it was not dissipated by somebody on board assuring me earnestly there was a camp of natives—he called them enemies!—hidden out of sight somewhere. We gave her her letters (I heard the men in that lonely ship were dying of fever at the rate of three a day) and went on. We called at some more places with farcical names, where the merry dance of death and trade goes on in a still and earthy atmosphere as of an overheated catacomb; all along the formless coast bordered by dangerous surf, as if Nature herself had tried to ward off intruders; in and out of rivers, streams of death in life, whose banks were rotting into mud, whose waters, thickened into slime, invaded the contorted mangroves, that seemed to writhe at us in the extremity of an impotent despair."

Comprehension & Inference

1. According to Conrad, what does the 'conquest of the earth' really involve?

2. How does the author describe the true motivations of the imperialists?

3. Why do you think this text was considered highly controversial when it was published in 1899?

The Riddle of the Sands

By Erskine Childers

"It was a glorious, breezy morning, and the waters of the Frisian coast danced and sparkled in the brilliant sunshine. We had brought the 'Dulcibella' through the tricky channels behind the islands, navigating the intricate maze of sandbanks that guarded the German shore. To the casual observer, we were merely a pair of eccentric English yachtsmen indulging in a late summer cruise among the desolate, mud-strewn estuaries of the North Sea. But beneath the facade of our holiday, a dark and terrifying suspicion had taken root in our minds—a suspicion that had driven us into these treacherous, shifting waters. As we dropped anchor in a narrow, desolate gut behind the island of Memmert, Davies stood by the mast, sweeping the horizon with his binoculars. The coastline here was a bleak, monotonous stretch of flat sand and grey water, seemingly devoid of human life. Yet, it was precisely this desolate emptiness that made it so perfect for a secret of such colossal magnitude. For weeks, we had been piecing together a puzzle made of innocuous clues: a tugboat operating where it had no business being, a mysterious salvage operation that recovered nothing, and the relentless, almost obsessive secrecy of a certain Herr Dollmann, an Englishman turned traitor in the service of the Kaiser. 'Look there,' Davies said quietly, handing me the glasses and pointing towards the mainland. 'Just past the spit of sand. Do you see it?' I squinted through the lenses. At first, there was nothing but the grey blur of the tidal flats. Then, as my eyes adjusted, I saw them. Not fishing boats, not merchantmen, but long, low shapes moving with mechanical precision through a dredged channel that did not exist on any of our Admiralty charts. They were lighters—massive, flat-bottomed barges designed for carrying troops and heavy equipment. There were dozens of them, moored in a hidden basin, sheltered from the open sea and completely invisible from the standard shipping lanes. The blood ran cold in my veins as the pieces of the terrible puzzle finally snapped into place. This was no innocent coastal defense project. The German Empire, cramped within its landlocked borders and burning with imperial ambition, was not merely building a High Seas Fleet to challenge our dreadnoughts in open battle. They were preparing something far more insidious, something that struck directly at the heart of our

island security. Behind the barrier of these Frisian islands, protected by the shifting sands and the treacherous tides, a vast, secret invasion force was being assembled. These hidden channels, newly deepened by relentless dredging, were designed to allow a flotilla of troop-carrying barges to slip out into the North Sea under the cover of darkness or a thick sea fog. They would bypass the mighty guns of the Royal Navy and strike a sudden, paralyzing blow on the unprotected eastern shores of England. We were sitting in the very nerve center of a meticulously organized naval conspiracy. The Kaiser's Germany was preparing to leap the moat. We alone held the secret, and our tiny, fragile yacht was the only thing standing between the oblivious British public and a sudden, catastrophic war. The riddle of the sands had been solved, but the true terror of what it meant for the future of our nation was only just beginning."

Comprehension & Inference

1. What secret threat did the narrator believe they had discovered?

2. According to the extract, why was the German Empire building its fleet?

3. How would reading a popular thriller like this have affected the British public's attitude toward Germany?

The Guns of August

By Barbara W. Tuchman

"The nations of Europe in the summer of 1914 were bound together by a series of treaties that were ostensibly designed for mutual defense. The theory behind these grand alliances was deterrence: if every major power was allied with another, the cost of aggression would be too high, and peace would be preserved. However, in reality, these treaties functioned not as safety nets, but as highly sensitive tripwires. The continent had become a rigid, inflexible machine, where a single spark could ignite the entire mechanism and drag millions into an unavoidable conflict. When the Archduke Franz Ferdinand was assassinated in the dusty streets of Sarajevo, the first of these tripwires was snapped. Austria-Hungary, determined to crush the irritating threat of Serbian nationalism, looked to its powerful ally, Germany, for support. The German Kaiser issued the infamous 'blank cheque,' a promise of unconditional backing that emboldened the Austrians to issue an ultimatum they knew Serbia could never fully accept. The localized crisis in the Balkans immediately began to pull the great powers into its gravitational vortex. Russia, presenting itself as the traditional protector of the Slavic people, felt compelled to stand by Serbia. But Russia's vast size was its greatest weakness; its army was massive but agonizingly slow to gather. To have any hope of fighting effectively, the Russian Tsar had to order mobilization immediately, long before diplomacy had run its course. Once the Tsar gave the order, the fatal clockwork of the alliance system took over. Mobilization in 1914 was not merely the calling up of reserves; it was an irrevocable step toward war. It meant the requisitioning of thousands of trains, the locking down of national borders, and the execution of highly detailed, down-to-the-minute railway timetables. For Germany, Russian mobilization triggered a terrifying strategic nightmare. Wedged between a hostile Russia to the east and a vengeful France to the west, the German military had devised the Schlieffen Plan. This plan dictated that Germany must immediately attack and defeat France in a lightning campaign of six weeks before the lumbering Russian army could reach the German borders. Therefore, when Russia mobilized, Germany could not wait. The German high command, terrified of fighting a two-front war, informed the civilian

government that military necessity must now dictate political action. They declared war on Russia, but, bound by the rigid logic of the Schlieffen Plan, their armies immediately marched in the opposite direction—invading neutral Belgium to strike at France. This violation of Belgian neutrality was the final tripwire. It outraged British public opinion and compelled the British Empire, tied to France and Russia by the Triple Entente, to declare war on Germany. In a matter of days, the entire continent had been plunged into disaster. The diplomats and politicians, who had spent the month of July sending frantic telegrams and attempting to bluff their way to victory, suddenly found themselves entirely powerless. The moment the mobilization orders were signed, control was handed over to the generals and their railway timetables. The statesmen of Europe had built a machine of alliances they believed would keep the peace, but once the gears started turning, it proved to be a machine of industrial slaughter that none of them could stop."

Comprehension & Inference

1. Why does the author describe the defensive alliances as 'tripwires'?

2. What metaphor is used to describe the outbreak of the war?

3. According to the text, why were the diplomats unable to stop the war once it started?

All Quiet on the Western Front

By Erich Maria Remarque

"We were eighteen years old, and we had only just begun to love life and the world; and we had to shoot it to pieces. Before the war, our lives were filled with the ordinary concerns of youth—school, parents, hobbies, and the vague, distant promises of the future. But all of that was swept away in a sudden, overwhelming tide of national fervor. The older generation, the men who sat comfortably in their armchairs and read the newspapers, told us it was our glorious duty to defend the Fatherland. They spoke of the Fatherland as if it were a beautiful, fragile thing that required our immediate sacrifice, and we, in our naive enthusiasm, believed them. The most persuasive of these voices belonged to our schoolmaster, Kantorek. He was a small, stern man who used to glare at us through his spectacles, pacing in front of the chalkboard. During drill-time, Kantorek gave us long, impassioned lectures about the honor of wearing the uniform and the sacred duty of the German soldier. He spoke of heroism and glory with such conviction that the whole of our class went, under his shepherding, straight to the District Commandant and volunteered. I can see him now, his voice trembling with emotion as he asked, 'Won't you join up, Comrades?' We were all at once terribly earnest. We marched out of the school gates feeling like men, ready to shoulder the destiny of the empire. No one had the vaguest idea what we were actually in for. The word 'war' was an abstract concept to us, a glorious adventure gleaned from history books and patriotic poetry. We pictured cavalry charges, gleaming medals, and a swift, victorious return home before the leaves fell from the trees. Kantorek called us the 'Iron Youth,' a phrase that made us stand a little taller and puff out our chests, completely unaware of the grim irony it would soon hold. It was only when we reached the training camps, and later the muddy, rat-infested trenches of the Western Front, that the glittering facade of duty and glory was violently stripped away. The first bombardment showed us our mistake, and under it the world as they had taught it to us broke in pieces. We realized that the authority of our teachers and parents, the people who were supposed to guide us into the world, was a lie. They had sent us out into a storm of steel with high-sounding words, but they had no conception of the reality of modern,

industrial slaughter. Out here in the mud, nobody cared about the 'Fatherland' or the grand political arguments of the Kaiser. We fought simply to survive, driven by instinct and a desperate loyalty to the men standing next to us in the trench. We had become a wasteland. The older men might have wives, children, and occupations to return to, a solid foundation built before the war. But for us, the young men of eighteen, the war was our only education. We were a generation of men who, even though they may have escaped shells, were destroyed by the war."

Comprehension & Inference

1. Who was Kantorek, and what did he persuade the entire class to do?

2. How did the adults, like teachers, use the idea of 'duty' or 'comradeship' to pressure young men?

3. How does this extract help explain the incredible surge of Nationalism and volunteering at the outbreak of the war?
